

The Healing TOUCH

A humanist doctor explains the science and art of medicine with a feel for philosophy

By Jaswant Singh



THE FORGOTTEN ART OF HEALING AND OTHER ESSAYS

by FAROKH UDWADIA
Oxford

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Dr Farokh Udwadia has authored a profound book, *The Forgotten Art of Healing*. To elaborate the theme I can do no better than let the author's own words speak: "This... is an attempt to express the essence of the art behind medicine" and its science. And Udwadia is unquestionably a master of both, the art and the science of medicine. To find this out for yourself, take a dip into this fine book. It has very moving essays, all imbued with a deep sense of humanity, of rare compassion, plus a renaissance feel for art, culture music and literature; the author effectively demonstrating how all these attributes enrich the 'science of medicine', and thus aid the 'art of healing'.

Udwadia explains that the "the art of medicine is the art of healing, not just treating, not even just curing. Yet it is only when art and science join hands that healing is best accomplished..." The author then adds, "For mercy's sake gentlemen, let us have a little less science and a little more art"; remember that the "practice of medicine is an art, not a trade, a calling, not a business; a

calling in which your heart will be exercised equally with your head". This book is a rare work of the art of medicine, from a very rare practitioner of the science of medicine.

The book is exceptional, for Udwadia is an exceptional doctor, also because as a doctor he combines attributes of the deepest sense of humanity with a very real feel for literature, also art, and conveys that the "heart that is not moved by music is fit for tyranny, stratagem and spoil". Music to Udwadia is the greatest of all art, for "great music in rare moments enables outwards, stretching out to infinity so as to commune with God".

There is in this work an essay on 'Religion and Medicine,' too, for example citing ancient Egypt and Greek and Roman manuscripts, like the Edwin Smith Papyrus found near Luxor, which dates back to 1600 B.C., describing medical practices of even earlier times. 'The link between medicine and religion was equally strong in ancient Sumer, India and China, as it was in Egypt. There is a moving recognition of the African approach, too, that "healing is a community affair... sharing and caring..."

Also in the book is a recognition of this "seething antagonism against contemporary medicine", born of "the mechanization of medicine... (also) the sin of commercialization... its crippling expenses in relation to investigations, treatment and the cost of hospitalization", and all this because the "art of medicine" has been "forgotten" by the "physicians of today"... who remain deeply immersed in its science". This, in turn, has resulted increasingly in seeking "relief through 'alternative medicine'".

This book is imbued with a great deal more than comments on medicine alone: it has poetry and lyrical descriptions of music, plus, most valuably, passages of great philosophical depth: "The second disadvantage of contemporary medicine... is the creation of an environment..." in which "...people in a society have lost their ability to look after themselves"—'social autogenesis', Udwadia terms it, a hopeless dependency.

A fascinating book, extremely readably written, a treatise on that essence of medicine: 'healing'; a philosophical work full of the spirit, ethics and personal value systems of a great doctor, a greater human being.



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